



THE PROPOSAL

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Anton Chekhov

About the Author:

Anton Pavlovich Chekhov (1860-1904) was a renowned Russian short story writer and playwright. He is considered one of the greatest masters of the modern short story. Chekhov was a doctor by profession, which gave him deep insight into human psychology and behaviour. His works are known for their realism, subtle humour, satire on society, and depiction of ordinary people's lives. He often highlighted human weaknesses like greed, ego, and foolishness in a light-hearted yet meaningful way. The Proposal (also known as A Marriage Proposal) is one of his most famous one-act plays, full of comedy and irony.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The absurdity and foolishness of arguments over petty matters.
- Marriage as a social and economic transaction rather than a romantic union.

- Human ego, pride, and short-tempered nature.
- The comic side of human relationships and misunderstandings.
- Materialism and property disputes in society.

Values:

- Importance of patience, tolerance, and forgiveness in relationships.
- Marriage should be based on understanding, not just property or arguments.
- We should control our anger and ego for peaceful living.
- Humour helps us see the silliness of our own behaviour.
- Respect and politeness are essential even during disagreements.

2. Characters

Stepan Stepanovitch Chubukov: A landowner, father of Natalya. He is elderly, greedy, and pretends to be polite but gets angry quickly.

Natalya Stepanovna: Chubukov's daughter, around 25 years old. She is argumentative, stubborn, and strong-willed. She wants to marry but fights over small things.

Ivan Vassilevitch Lomov: Neighbour of Chubukov, around 35 years old. He is a rich but nervous and hypochondriac landowner who imagines he is ill. He comes with a marriage proposal but is very quarrelsome.

3. Summary

The Proposal is a one-act comic play that takes place in the drawing room of Chubukov's house in a Russian village. The entire story happens in a single setting and lasts less than an hour, yet it is packed with humour and irony.

The play opens with Ivan Lomov arriving at his neighbour Chubukov's house dressed in formal clothes. Chubukov is surprised but welcomes him

warmly, thinking Lomov has come to borrow something. Lomov is extremely nervous and hesitant. After some awkward conversation, he finally reveals the real purpose of his visit - he has come to propose marriage to Chubukov's daughter, Natalya.

Chubukov is overjoyed because Lomov is a rich, young landowner. He immediately calls Natalya into the room, telling her that Lomov has come to propose. Before leaving the two alone, Chubukov blesses them happily.

As soon as Natalya enters, Lomov tries to propose but becomes very nervous. Instead of directly saying he loves her, he starts talking about how their families have been good neighbours for a long time and how it would be beneficial if they got married. He mentions his heart problem and other health issues. Natalya, not understanding that this is a marriage proposal, thinks he has come to discuss some land or business matter.

The conversation suddenly shifts to an argument. Lomov says that his land Oxen Meadows belongs to him. Natalya strongly disagrees and claims that Oxen Meadows has always belonged to her family. Both become extremely angry and start shouting at each other. They insult each other's family members and accuse one another of lying. Lomov calls Natalya's family dishonest, while Natalya calls Lomov rude and impolite.

Chubukov hears the noise and rushes in. When he learns about the argument, he also joins the fight. He supports his daughter and starts abusing Lomov. All three shout at the top of their voices. Lomov becomes so stressed that he feels his heart is failing and he collapses on a chair.

At this moment, Chubukov and Natalya suddenly realise that Lomov had actually come with a marriage proposal. Their attitude changes instantly. They forget the fight and start praising Lomov. Natalya becomes sweet and polite. When Lomov regains consciousness, they quickly ask him if he still wants to marry Natalya. Lomov, still confused, agrees. Within moments, Chubukov blesses the couple, and the two start arguing again - this time about whose dog is better, Lomov's dog Guess or Natalya's dog Squeezer.

The play ends with Chubukov saying in relief, "She's agreed! She's agreed!" while the couple continues quarrelling. The curtain falls, showing the comic and absurd nature of the situation.

Through this short, fast-paced play, Chekhov brilliantly exposes how ego, greed, and petty arguments can spoil even important occasions like marriage.

4. Moral (in points)

- Petty arguments and ego can destroy important relationships and opportunities.
- Marriage should not be treated only as a business deal involving land and property.
- We should learn to control our anger and speak politely.
- Human behaviour is often absurd and contradictory.
- Forgiveness and understanding are more important than winning small arguments.
- Appearances can be deceptive - people change their attitude according to self-interest.
- True happiness comes from harmony, not from winning fights.
- We should value relationships over material possessions.

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